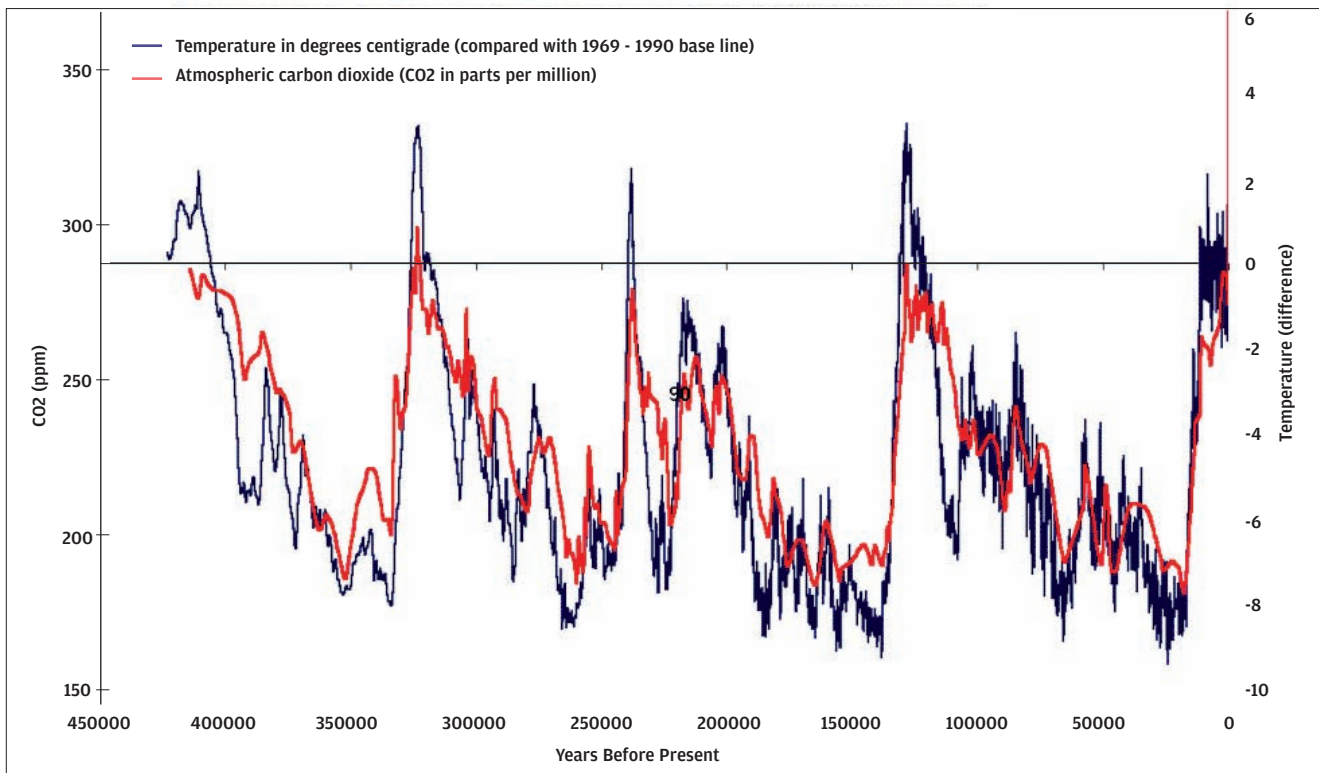




feature

10% of rated

Roughly, the power consumption of your electronic devices on standby



Graph of the Antarctic ice-core data, used so dramatically and misleadingly in Al Gore's film, *An Inconvenient Truth*. If you could zoom in closely, you would see that CO₂ changes follow changes in temperature, not the other way around, as Gore makes out. Chart kindly made available by Dr. Tom Rees

Many green activists want to see a dramatic reduction in human populations; a few even want to see humans disappear altogether. These are not all minor and inconsequential extremists. The President of the World Wildlife Fund has stated: "If I were reincarnated, I would wish to be returned to Earth as a killer virus to lower human population levels." The more moderate ones want us to return to a subsistence style level, rather like the pre-industrial world. For example, Pentti Linkola, the Finnish "ecophilosopher": "Everything we have developed over the last 100 years should be destroyed." At least these ones are honest in their intentions. Others seem to have motives of political and financial control at heart.

Take Al Gore as an example. There is no real physical evidence that CO₂ levels are driving temperatures upwards, and yet that is the impression he gives in his film, *"An Inconvenient Truth"*. If real evidence actually existed, he would not have to make it up, as he does. For many, the most compelling piece of "evidence" that he gives — the only one, really — is the graph taken from Antarctic ice-core drillings that shows CO₂ and temperature closely in step. He states in the film: "When there is more carbon dioxide, the temperature gets warmer, because it traps more heat from the sun inside."

The graph shows data across several hundred thousand years, and so you cannot see much detail. What Gore misses out is that if you look more closely at this and many other ice-core data sets, you find that CO₂ starts to rise or fall several hundred years after the temperature starts to rise or fall. This simple fact alone destroys Gore's position, although many activists have tried to come up with logic why it does not. The mechanism is simple, and understandable by a high-school science student: as temperatures rise, the water in the oceans is able to hold less CO₂ in solution, and so the gas is emitted into the atmosphere. As temperatures fall, the reverse occurs. The numbers also match up reasonably well from calculations that have been done on the basis of the ice-core data.

It is rather difficult to read the scientific literature on this subject without being aware of the lag between temperature

and CO₂; it is very well known. It is therefore highly unlikely that Al Gore was unaware of this fact. It could be that he was very badly advised, but if not, the logic suggests that as it did not fit his agenda, he did not include it — perhaps this lag is the really inconvenient truth.

What agenda might that be? Gore is involved with carbon trading in a big way, with his company "Generation Investment Management". The more people he is able to scare with his propaganda film, the more they are likely to buy carbon offsets, and bring revenues to his and other similar companies. In recent months, it has been reported that the last few slides of presentations that he has given have promoted investment opportunities in this whole carbon-trading scam. Incidentally, there are many other "errors" in Gore's film — 35 according to Christopher Monckton — but let's leave him there.

One often hears that there is a world-wide scientific consensus in favour of the CO₂ theory. Tellingly, the word consensus is a political term, usually unheard of in scientific circles. Anyway, this is simply not true — there are many climate and other scientists that oppose this view, apparently many even within the IPCC itself. So what do these other scientists say is causing the changes to our climate? Mostly, the Sun, the single source of the heat in our atmosphere (there is a tiny fraction from geological activity). The theory is complex, but in its briefest form, galactic cosmic rays entering the atmosphere seed the formation of clouds at lower levels in the atmosphere that then reflect sunlight and tend to cool the Earth. When the Sun is less active, it not only provides slightly less radiant heat to the Earth, but also its solar wind and magnetic field are weaker, allowing more cosmic rays through to our lower atmosphere. When the Sun is more active, the reverse is the case, and this complex mechanism involving the solar wind, magnetic field and cosmic rays effectively amplifies the changes in the radiant output of the Sun; it amplifies the effect on temperatures here. This solar theory also does a good job of explaining the ice-ages of the last half billion years, and even the earlier snowball-Earth episodes.